

Mokurai-oshō (黙雷和尚) — Biography Notes

Background research on the founder of 自然宗佛國寺 (Shizenshū Bukkokuji), ahead of Rob's planned October 2026 visit. See [[project_mokurai_genmyo_kagoshima_temple]] for the outreach history and [[project_bukkokuji_visit_idea]] for the visit planning. Compiled from the temple's own site (bukokuji.jimdofree.com, morino-ohaka.jimdofree.com), a Wedge Online investigative article, a CBC News report, and a note.com profile — all secondary/self-reported sources unless noted otherwise. Not independently verified by Claude beyond reading the cited pages; treat pre-1991 biography especially as Mokurai's own account, not confirmed record.

Names

- **Personal name:** 伊藤黙雷 (Itō Mokurai), per the temple's own bio.
- **Religious/public name:** 黙雷 (Mokurai), also 佛國寺黙雷, 黙雷和尚, 勸進僧黙雷.
- **"黙雷玄明" (Mokurai Genmyō):** the signature on the 1997 林野行政 essay found in Mitsue's own 100-year document set. The 玄明 (Genmyō) component is *not* corroborated by any other source found so far — flag as unconfirmed until asked directly.
- Current age: 85 (as of 2026), implying a birth year of roughly 1940–41. No independently verified birth date, birthplace, or family background found.

Timeline

Date	Event
~1940–41	Born (approximate, from stated current age; unverified)
1950s	As a middle-school student, wrote to JCP chairman Nosaka Sanzō asking to join the party — refused
—	Member of 大日本愛国党 (Great Japan Patriotic Party, right-wing); separately worked as a 書生 (live-in aide) for Nakasone Yasuhiro (per his own account to Wedge)
1960-10	Claims to have been present at the assassination of JSP chairman Asanuma Inejirō; says he might have ended up playing the role Yamaguchi Otoya did (unverified, self-reported)
—	A period of 人生の成功 (success) followed by 事業の失敗 (business failure) and betrayal — the temple's own account calls it a "hell of worldly desire"; triggers a 一大発心 (profound resolve) to change his life. No detail found on what the business was.
1961-02-17	Enters 臨濟宗月桂禅寺 (Tokyo, Rinzai Zen) under 松尾太年老師, later 216th abbot of Engaku-ji, Kamakura
1963-05-05	Ordained under 長屋真乗禅師 of 龍雲寺, Mie Prefecture
1970-11	21-day fast at 水間寺 (Mizuma-dera, Osaka), founder's hall, under 今東光 (Kon Tōkō) — Tendai 大僧正, also novelist, former House of Councillors member, public intellectual

Date	Event
1983-08 – 1989-12	Seven-and-a-half-year pilgrimage around Japan (求道の廻国行) as a 乞食雲水 (begging/wandering monk) — refused lodging by many temples, slept under bridges/in mountains, welcomed at convents in Ōmi, Echizen, Kaga, Etchū
1985-12-12	佛國寺 formally recognized as a religious corporation by Mie Prefecture (mid-pilgrimage)
1991-12-08 – 1992-03-25	100-day street sitting practice (百日間下座行), Osaka/Umeda — triggered by the Kyoto Buddhist Association refusing him temple admission; framed as asking "what should a monk actually be"
1999	Street practice outside the Ministry of Finance concerning rural-community reconstruction
1999-09-03	いのちの森 trademark registered (商標登録第4310763号)
1999–2004	Attempts forest regeneration / mountain-village reconstruction in "a water-source village in Nara Prefecture" (his own site's あゆみ page) — hits institutional/physical/mindset walls, withdraws. Not yet confirmed this was Mitsue specifically — same era/region as Shaku Myōen's remark about a prior Mitsue energy project, but unconfirmed.
2000	佛國寺 renamed 自然宗佛國寺
2004	Severe typhoon damage in Ōsugi Valley (大杉谷), Mie
2005 (late)	Enters Ōsugi Valley; with 14 local residents establishes 株式会社大杉谷自立再生機構, aiming for 山村自立再生 (autonomous mountain-village revitalization), explicitly rejecting subsidy dependence (自助自立・相互扶助). Involves people from METI, MAFF, Mie Prefecture, universities, political/business circles — but self-reliance was the stated principle.
2006	CBC News reports Mokurai bought mountain land in Ōdai-chō specifically to start a wood biomass power generation business. Not corroborated by his own extensive self-documentation (zero mention of biomass/electricity/power anywhere on his own sites) — single-source claim, unresolved.
—	大杉谷自立再生機構 project collapses amid conflict with outside environmental activists demanding zero human intervention (緑をまもれ／木を伐るな／自然に人の手を加えるな／山に経済を持ち込むな)
2007-07-05	24ha parcel at 伊勢大杉谷 (Ise Ōsugidani) registered — 12ha 50–60yr sugi/hinoki plantation + 12ha natural secondary broadleaf
2007	Headquarters/寺務所 moves to 大台町桧原, Ōdai-chō, Mie (present operating base; the Kagoshima address remains as 祖院, ancestral temple, still maintained)
2007–2014	Multiple 21-day 下座行 (street prostration/begging pilgrimages) in Osaka, Kyoto, Kobe, Nagoya, Tokyo
2012	At age 71, walks ~2,000km from Akime-ura, Kagoshima (Ganjin's landing site) to Tokyo

Date	Event
2014-06-10	+1.5ha parcel at 大台町茂原 (Ōdai-chō Shigehara) acquired — 基本財産林 (endowment forest)
2015	Tōkaidō pilgrimage protesting a Chinese capital plan to buy ~1,400ha of forest including their own Ōsugidani watershed; publishes 『東海道行脚・洗心自新録』
2016-02-26	いのちの森 forest-burial service formally begins, run by Shaku Myōen as 薬師庵主 (a role she's held at the temple since 1991-04-29)
2024-07-21	CBC News investigative report on いのちの森 — raises legal/regulatory concerns (remains left uncovered by soil, not technically "buried"; local resident objections; Mokurai's own position that the site doesn't constitute a legal cemetery; Ministry of Health/Labour view is that unburied remains fall outside cemetery law)
2026 (undated)	Wedge Online investigative profile — corroborates the broad "success → betrayal → pilgrimage" arc, describes the temple building as a converted former inn (3-story wooden), cites land as ~21ha (a third, unreconciled figure vs. the 243,000 m² / 255,000 m² cited elsewhere)
2026-09-07	Rob mails a letter to the Kagoshima address, which forwards it
2026-09-14	Shaku Myōen replies on Mokurai's behalf (he doesn't use email/SNS); confirms current Mie address and Ōdai-chō base; grants permission for Rob to ask questions; reveals prior institutional involvement — "国と県と仏国寺で、新エネルギーに取り組みました" (national government, prefecture, and Bukkokuji worked together on new energy) in Mitsue Village itself, alongside a claim they're "planning something similar to your project"; defers detail to an in-person meeting
2026-09-15	Dome (advisor) confirms he does not know Mokurai — no independent corroboration from this channel

Self-conception: 勧進僧 (kanjin-sō)

Mokurai identifies not as a conventional temple priest but as a 勧進僧 — invoking the historical tradition of monks like 行基 (Gyōki), who traveled Japan soliciting public support for Buddhist works (e.g. Tōdai-ji). His modern version: walk → encounter people → receive support → build something for society. He treats walking/begging/fasting as the religious practice itself, not merely fundraising.

Poem he associates with his own role:

人をのみ渡し渡して おのが身は 岸に上がらぬ 渡し守かな

"I ferry people across, one after another, yet I myself never reach the shore — like the ferryman."

Institutional philosophy — 自然宗

- Presents itself as a return to Shakyamuni's original teaching, deliberately non-sectarian (rejects 宗派意識, sectarian consciousness, which he felt Buddhism had become too attached to during his pilgrimage years).

- Followers are called 学徒 (**gakushō**, "**students**"), not the traditional 信者/信徒 — the idea being everyone remains a lifelong student on the path toward becoming Buddha.
- Explicitly prohibits hereditary succession of 住持職 and 副住持職 (abbot roles) — a temple should be a public religious institution, not family property.
- Recognized as a religious corporation by MEXT.

いのちの森 (Forest of Life) — the forest-burial business

- Run by Shaku Myōen (釈妙円) as 薬師庵主.
- Model: natural-burial fees fund forest restoration/maintenance in a closed loop — payment (~¥210,000/person for perpetual memorial care) → forest upkeep → forest becomes the resting place → forest survives.
- Explicitly distinguished by Myōen from 樹木葬 ("tree burial"), the more common commercial term.
- Land: figures vary across sources — 243,000 m² (temple's own site), 255,000 m² (two-parcel sum from morino-ohaka.jimdofree.com: 24ha Ise Ōsugidani + 1.5ha Ōdai-chō Shigehara), ~21ha (Wedge). Not reconciled — worth asking directly.
- Legal status is contested: remains are left uncovered by soil rather than technically "buried"; local objections reported; Mokurai's own stated position is that the site isn't a legal cemetery, which he treats as compatible with current law given remains aren't buried. A real reputational/legal consideration before any closer or public association with the temple — doesn't affect the personal/authorship relationship with Rob, but should inform how visibly Rob links the Mitsue project to Bukkokuji in outreach or media.
- The temple explicitly refuses government subsidies on principle: their own Q&A states accepting subsidies "robs people of the spirit of independence" and locks recipients into "national-prefectural-municipal-forest cooperative control." A real philosophical friction point given Rob's project leans on METI/MoE grants — worth navigating carefully.

Land — physical detail

Two parcels, both within Ōdai-chō but not co-located with the administrative office:

- **伊勢大杉谷 (Ise Ōsugidani):** 24ha, registered 2007-07-05. 12ha 50–60yr sugi/hinoki plantation + 12ha natural secondary broadleaf. Extremely remote/roadless mountain terrain — satellite imagery inconclusive without land-registry parcel (地番) data.
- **大台町茂原 (Ōdai-chō Shigehara):** 1.5ha, acquired 2014-06-10, held as 基本財産林 (endowment forest).
- **寺務所 (administrative office), 〒519-2632 大台町桧原175番地:** just the office — not the forest land itself, which is why satellite imagery there shows no forest structures.
- **祖院 (ancestral temple), 〒898-0101 鹿児島県南さつま市坊津町坊7135番地:** still separately maintained; forwards mail to Mie. Not a "relocation" so much as two co-existing sites.

Open questions (unresolved, for the October meeting)

1. Was the 1999–2004 "water-source village in Nara Prefecture" reconstruction attempt specifically Mitsue, or a different candidate village?
2. What exactly was the 2006 wood-biomass power venture (CBC's only source) — technology used

(gasification vs. steam/Rankine vs. heat-only), why it isn't in his own self-documentation, why it stopped?

3. Is 玄明 (Genmyō) a real second dharma-name component, or a misattribution?
4. What business failed pre-1983, and what was the nature of the "betrayal"?
5. What specifically was the Nakasone/Asanuma relationship — verifiable, or self-mythologizing?
6. What exactly went wrong with 大杉谷自立再生機構 (the 2005–2006 revitalization project) — useful as a preview of frictions Mitsue's own project could hit, given both lean on a self-reliance-over-subsidy framing.
7. Reconcile the three different land-area figures (243,000 m² / 255,000 m² / ~21 ha).
8. His and Myōen's English ability is greeting-level at best — confirm interpreter plan (see [[project_bukokuji_visit_idea]]) before the visit.

Sources

- Temple's own site: bukokuji.jimdofree.com (multiple pages, incl. 住職・勸進僧・黙雷 and 自著『仏心』)
- morino-ohaka.jimdofree.com (いのちの森 project site, distinct from the main temple site)
- Wedge Online: 「森のお墓」は山村を守れるのか？ (2026), multi-page investigative feature
- CBC News: なぜ山にむき出しの遺骨が？ (2024-07-21)
- note.com: 人は何を守るべきか「黙雷和尚の道標」 by osamukayama
- Direct correspondence with Shaku Myōen via bukokuji@gmail.com, 2026-09